The fates were kind. Dale picked up a couple of wickets in the Western Province first innings, and I managed to score a couple of half-centuries, making 58 in an opening partnership of 122 with Alviro Petersen in our first innings and then contributing 61 to a second-wicket stand of 114 with Martin van Jaarsveld in our second. In each innings, I was out caught off the slow left-arm orthodox bowling of Claude Henderson. The match was drawn and, to their relief, the two unknown debutants had managed to look decent.

A week later, we drove 45 minutes down the N1 to Johannesburg to play Gauteng at the Wanderers, and again I managed to get some runs, scoring 62 and then 54 as we won the game by 223 runs. Justin Kemp and Paul Harris, with six for 59 in their second innings, were our heroes but I was pleased to have played my part and to have launched my first-class career with four consecutive 50s in my first four innings.

Did I know what was going on?

Not really; I was simply trying to survive and not look stupid.

The inevitable bump back down to earth came quickly. I scored 0 and 17 when we lost at home to Border, and was left out of the side when senior players returned for the match against North West.

What was next?

Living from week to week, playing from match to match, I was selected for the South African Under-19 squad to participate in the Commonwealth Under-19 Championships, but not in Durban or Cape Town ... in India. So we headed overseas again and spent three weeks in the subcontinent, far from home over Christmas and New Year.

Faf du Plessis and JP Duminy were in that team, and I remember we used to go for early morning jogs through the chilly streets of Lucknow. Eight teams were divided into two groups for the 50-over tournament and we continued our form from England, played well and reached the final at the Nahar Singh Stadium in Faridabad. Things were running my way again and, still believing that almost every ball was there to be hit, I